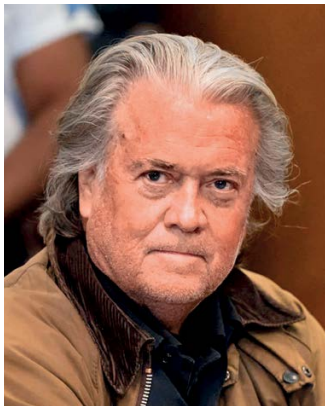


"The reason I'm in America along with so many critical people...is because of H-1B. I will go to war on this issue the like of which you can't comprehend"

ELON MUSK
Future head, DOGE



"H1-B visas? It's about taking American jobs and bringing over...indentured servants at lower wages. This is a scam by oligarchs in Silicon Valley"

STEVE BANNON
Former Trump advisor

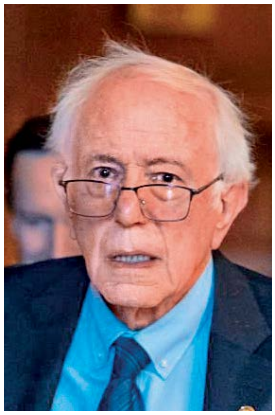
"Why top tech firms hire foreign-born engineers comes down to American culture.... It has venerated mediocrity over excellence for way too long"

VIVEK RAMASWAMY
Future co-head, DOGE



"The main function of the H-1B programme is...to replace paying American jobs with low wage indentured servants from abroad.... The corporate abuse of H-1B must end"

BERNIE SANDERS
Democrat Senator



alumnus of IIT Madras and University of California, Berkeley, and an H-1B visa-holder, had worked at OpenAi, the start-up that built ChatGPT, before he ventured his own AI search engine Perplexity. "I think I should get a green card. Wdyt?" went his post on X, using social media slang for 'What do you think'. A green card, known officially as a Permanent Resident Card, allows a person to live and work permanently in the United States, unlike temporary work visas like the H-1B. The answer came soon enough, from the one man who is sure to matter in the new Trump dispensation, the tech billionaire Elon Musk. It was a single word—"Yes."

MAGA men were up in arms against that endorsement from the man who owns Tesla, X and SpaceX, trolling him heavily for backing H-1B holders like Srinivas. Not one to take things lying down, Musk lashed out, "The reason I'm in America along with so many critical people who built SpaceX, Tesla and a hundred other companies that made America strong is because of H-1B...I will go to war on this issue the like of which you cannot possibly comprehend." MAGA supporters read these words as an inversion of their anti-immigrant stance, by a person whom Trump has already nominated to lead the new Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE). Vivek Ramaswamy, Musk's co-chair of DOGE and a former Republican presidential candidate, weighed in, too, with a critique of American culture and standards of education, which he said had "venerated mediocrity over excellence for way too long".

That set the cat among the MAGA pigeons, with Steve Bannon, a former Trump advisor and a hardliner on immigration, hitting back thus: "H-1B visas? That's not what it's about. It's about taking American jobs and bringing over essentially what have become indentured servants at lower wages. This thing is a scam by oligarchs in Silicon Valley." Laura Looner, a far right-wing provocateur and internet influencer, joined the debate after Trump appointed Sriram Krishnan, an Indian American venture capitalist, as an advisor on artificial intelligence policy. He, like Musk, is known to favour bringing in more skilled immigrants to the US. Looner called Krishnan's stance a "not America First policy".

Support for the MAGA lobby came from unexpected quarters—the far left. Bernie Sanders, the Democrat Senator from Vermont, lashed out at Musk for his H-1B stand, taking to X to say: "The main function of the H-1B program is not to hire the best and the brightest but rather to replace good paying American jobs with low wage indentured servants from abroad. The cheaper the labour they hire, the more money the billionaires make. The widespread corporate abuse of the H-1B program must be ended." Sanders charged that, in 2022 and 2023 alone, the top 30 American corporations used the programme